



SAINA NEHWAL

The world junior badminton champion now dreams of a place among the top 10 in the world and experts are unanimous in their belief that this fearless Hyderabad shuttler has all the attributes needed to become the best in the world

Serving SMASHES

By Amarnath K. Menon

At 18, she is raring to go where no Indian woman has been before—to be crowned the world's best in her sport. Her latest triumph, winning the World Junior Badminton Championship at Pune shows that the sprightly Saina Nehwal has will power, tenacity and the drive to keep putting in the effort to make her dreams come true.

Nehwal is the first Indian to clinch the World Junior Badminton Championship and is the leader of a clutch of Indians winning major titles in the sport. "Saina has phenomenal potential, and age and agility are on her side," says national coach and former All England champion Pullela Gopichand who has worked with Nehwal for three years now. When the Hyderabad took on and beat the eight-time reigning national champion Aparna Popat in the Asian Satellite Badminton Championship in Delhi three years ago, even badminton buffs dismissed her merely as the brightest of an emerging brat pack. Popat, until then the most successful Indian woman player of all time, had not lost to a fellow Indian in four years, but few were willing to name Nehwal her successor.

Then came a string of victories in 2006, including the Philippines Open, which made Nehwal the first Indian woman to win a four-star badminton event. Entering the Philippines tournament ranked 86th, Nehwal went on to stun several top-seeded players, including World No. 4 Huaiwen Xu before defeating Julia Xian Pei Wong of Malaysia for the title. To a country in the grip of a Sania-mania, the emergence of another young woman from Hyderabad with a similar-sounding name, who also wielded a mean racket, was all too confusing. Today she is no more mistaken for the tennis sensation, in either word or deed.

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